

KEEP THE PROOF — VERSION 2

Complete reader-facing manuscript (Stage 2, for review)

Prepared for Temidayo Afonja, The Density Group. September 18, 2026.

This is the complete reader-facing manuscript, not an outline and not the final designed product. It is for review only. No final production PDF has been generated. Design, layout, and the visual system are applied only after this manuscript and the Professional Record are approved.

Conventions in this manuscript. Body text is the reader-facing copy. Lines marked > **VISUAL** : describe an intended visual teaching device or artifact for the design stage; they are not reader-facing text. Blocks marked **LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED** are placeholders whose final wording is withheld pending counsel; no interim legal guidance is invented. Completed examples are shown as they will appear, as filled-in record cards.

FRONT MATTER

Cover

KEEP THE PROOF

A guided system for building your professional record

For performance reviews, internal moves, career pivots, re-entry and unexpected change.

Temidayo Afonja · temidayoafonja.com

VISUAL: The established Keep the Proof cover identity, unchanged in system. Deep navy ground, cream serif title, one short gold rule, the descriptor and supporting line beneath. Remove any "60-Minute" line. Price is not printed on the cover.

The record and the fine print

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What this guide is, and what it is not

This is an educational guide to keeping a private, permitted record of your own work. It is not legal advice. It cannot interpret your specific employment agreement, your non-disclosure obligations, your employer's policies, or the laws that apply where you work. Where a question of permission is genuinely unclear, treat that as a signal to leave the information out and to ask someone qualified, such as your manager, your human resources team, or an attorney.

A note on confidentiality before you begin

Everything in this system is built on one rule: you record only your own recollection of your work and information you are permitted to keep. You will be asked, repeatedly, not to copy, forward, photograph, download, screenshot, or reconstruct anything your employer owns. That rule holds on any device, at any hour, in any format. It is the first thing this guide teaches and the last thing it will let you forget.

LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED: The not-legal-advice statement and confidentiality note carry over from Version 1 and are confirmed for Version 2 by counsel before release.

Written and designed by Temidayo Afonja, Founder and Principal, The Density Group.
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Welcome

Most people do excellent work and remember almost none of it clearly.

Not because the work was small. Because the work was constant. You solved the problem, absorbed the lesson, and moved to the next thing before the last one had a name. Months later a review, a promotion case, or a sudden change asks you to account for a year, and you find yourself reaching for details that have already gone soft.

Across my career I have worked in and around talent, workforce, and organizational decisions: conversations about performance, promotion, restructuring, and readiness. One pattern kept surfacing, and it was simpler than the politics of any single room. Capable people would reach an important career moment and then have to reconstruct the work that had brought them to it. Some could describe their contribution clearly. Others knew they had done meaningful work but no longer had the details.

Whether you can describe your work does not decide who gets promoted, hired, or selected. Sponsorship, opportunity, timing, business conditions, and plenty of things outside any one person's control shape those outcomes. What an accurate record does affect is narrower and still worth a great deal: how clearly your work can be understood when a decision depends on it. That part is learnable, and it is mostly a matter of keeping a record while the facts are still available to you.

Keep the Proof is that record and the discipline around it. It will not tell you what your career means or what move to make. It will help you hold on to the truth of your own work, in language a

stranger can understand, kept in a way that respects the people you work for. That is a smaller promise than most career products make. It is also one you can actually keep.

Temidayo Afonja, Founder and Principal, The Density Group

Why you might be here

You did not come to this guide for a definition. You came because something is happening, or is about to.

Maybe a review is coming and you cannot clearly recall the year. Maybe you were promoted in responsibility but not in title, and you are doing work no one has written down. Maybe your access just closed, and the record of what you did is now behind a door you cannot open. Maybe you have been in one place for fifteen years and you are not sure your work would read to anyone outside it. Maybe you are going back after a break. Maybe you were acquired, and new owners are asking who you are.

VISUAL: A set of short, plain situation lines, each one a sentence a real reader would recognize as theirs. One of them is the reader's. This page is a mirror, not a menu. No frameworks yet.

Underneath all of them is the same quiet thought: I know I did good work, and now I cannot quite lay my hands on the details. You are not trying to build a case yet, or impress anyone. You just want the truth of what you did, and the judgment and the decisions inside it, to still be there when you reach for it.

These are different circumstances. They share one first job.

Different circumstances. Same first job: build an accurate account of the work.

Before you can decide anything, translate anything for anyone, or make any case, you need a truthful record of what you actually did. That record is what this guide builds. Everything else, including what your work means and where it could go, is a later question and, in some cases, a different tool. This one starts with the truth of the work itself.

Two ways in

There are two ways into this system, and they are equally valid. Choose the one that matches where you are standing right now.

Capturing now? Start here.

You still have your access, your systems, your memory of recent work. You are in the best possible position, because you can capture the record while the facts are fresh. Begin with Your First 60 Minutes, then let the habit carry it forward.

Already lost access? Start here.

The change has already happened. The systems are closed and the record you wish you had does not exist yet. You have not failed, and you did not buy the wrong guide. You simply start differently, by rebuilding a useful account from what is still yours. Turn to Part Seven, Reconstruct, and use the reconstruct version of Your First 60 Minutes.

VISUAL: Two clearly labeled doors, side by side, equal in weight. Neither is the lesser path.

How to use this guide, and the one rule

This guide has three jobs. It helps you capture what happened, clarify what was actually yours, and carry it forward in language an outsider can follow. Those three words, Capture, Clarify, Carry, are the whole shape of the system, and the next pages give you each one in turn.

You can read straight through in an unhurried sitting, or jump to the part you need. Wherever a tool appears, a completed example appears with it, so you are never looking at an empty box wondering what belongs there. Permission and protection run through the entire guide rather than sitting in one block, because they apply to every entry you make.

The one rule that never bends

You record your own recollection and information you are permitted to retain. You never copy, forward, or reconstruct material your employer owns. If permission is unclear, you leave it out. Everything else in this guide sits underneath that rule.

PART ONE — UNDERSTAND THE RECORD

What a professional record is, and why it goes missing. Kept short, because you already recognized yourself on the way in.

The opening question

If your work access disappeared this afternoon, how much of the record of your work would disappear with it?

Picture the ordinary version of a bad day. Not a scandal, just a change. A reorganization removes your login by five o'clock. A role is eliminated with two weeks' notice. A system migration wipes three years of your sent mail. You are fine, professionally and otherwise. But the record of what you did now lives in systems you can no longer open.

What would you still have? For most capable people the honest answer is a current title, a rough sense of their projects, and a handful of numbers they are not quite sure of. The specific decisions, the problems they caught before anyone noticed, the exact shape of the thing they built, all of it sat inside the work, and the work is behind a door that just closed.

This guide is built for the stretch of time between two sentences. The first is I am doing the work. The second is I suddenly need to explain what the work amounted to. That gap is usually months or years long, and almost nobody uses it. Keep the Proof is how you use it.

Why a professional record goes missing

It is tempting to blame memory. Memory is part of it, but it is not the main cause. A professional record disappears for reasons that are structural, and once you see them you can design around them.

It lives in systems you do not own. Your accomplishments are recorded, but not by you and not for you. They sit in a ticketing system, a shared drive, a customer platform, an email account, a chat history. Every one of those belongs to your employer. Access to them is a condition of your role, and it ends when the role does.

It is written in a private language. Inside a company, work is described in shorthand: project code names, internal acronyms, team rituals. That shorthand is efficient at work and meaningless everywhere else. A record written only in internal language is a record only your current employer can read.

The best parts are the least visible. The work that most deserves to be remembered often leaves the faintest trace. A judgment call that prevented a bad outcome produces no artifact, because the bad outcome never happened. Coordination across three teams shows up in no single person's numbers. The quieter and more valuable the contribution, the more likely it is to vanish without a deliberate record.

It decays quietly. Details do not leave all at once. They fade. The figure you were sure of becomes approximate. The reason behind a decision blurs into the decision itself. Six months on, you can still tell the story, but you can no longer defend the specifics, and specifics are what a review or a resume runs on.

What a professional record is, and is not

A professional record is a truthful, private, retrievable account of what you contributed, what judgment you exercised, what changed because of your work, and what permitted information supports it. That is the whole definition, and each word in it is doing work.

VISUAL: The two-column is / is-not table, retained from Version 1.

A professional record is a record of your contribution and judgment. It is not a list of everything you were assigned. It is written in language an outsider can follow, not a wall of internal names and acronyms. It is honest about your part in a shared result, not a claim of sole credit for team work. It is built only from what you may keep, not a copy of files that belong to your employer. It is useful before many career moments, not a document you touch only when job hunting.

It is disciplined recordkeeping, not self-promotion. The point is not to make your work sound impressive. The point is to make it accurate and findable, so that when a moment arrives that depends on the details, the details are there and you can trust them. Done well, an accurate account is more persuasive than an inflated one, because it holds up when someone asks a second question.

A note on the word most people reach for. Some people call this a brag document. That name is understandable, and this guide is not at war with it. What you are building is closer to evidence than to bragging, and the difference is practical: it gives someone else something concrete to consider. Use whatever word helps you start. The discipline is the same.

What is worth capturing

You cannot record everything, and you should not try. Activity is not contribution. Answering forty emails is activity. Deciding which of the forty actually needed a decision, and getting that one right, is contribution. The filter below keeps the record small and worth keeping.

Capture it if one of these is true.

- You exercised judgment, made a decision, or chose between real options.
- Something changed, improved, or became possible because of what you did.
- You prevented a problem, a cost, a delay, or a risk that would otherwise have landed.
- You handled scope, scale, or complexity that a description of your title would not reveal.
- You coordinated, influenced, or unblocked work across people or functions.
- You received specific feedback, recognition, or a result you can honestly point to.

Let it go if it is only this.

- Routine execution of your basic duties with nothing distinctive about how you did it.
- Attendance, hours, or effort with no observable change attached.
- A task you were assigned but did not meaningfully shape.

A simple test. Before you record something, ask: if I described this to a thoughtful stranger, would they understand what I actually contributed and why it mattered? If the honest answer is no, either find the contribution underneath the activity, or leave it out.

The boundary: your account versus employer-owned artifacts

This is the distinction the whole system depends on, so it is worth stating plainly. Your professional record is your own account of your work. An employer-owned artifact is the material itself: the deck, the model, the code, the client file, the report. As a practical rule, the account is yours to keep, and the artifact is not.

VISUAL: The two-column table of account versus artifact, retained from Version 1, with the three paired rows (onboarding, access gap, vendor selection).

Yours to keep is your own sentence about what you did: "I rebuilt the onboarding process and cut new-hire ramp time." Not yours is the onboarding deck, the HR system export, the employee list. Yours to keep: "I found and closed a gap in how we granted system access." Not yours: the access logs, the security configuration, the audit tooling. Yours to keep: "I led the vendor selection and negotiated better terms." Not yours: the signed contract, the pricing sheet, the internal cost model.

Notice what the left column has in common. Each entry is a sentence you could say out loud in a hallway without exposing anything your employer owns. The right column is the underlying material, and none of it belongs in a personal record, no matter how convenient it would be to keep.

The line you will learn to hear. If the thing you want to save is a file, a screenshot, an export, or a copy of anything produced at work, it is an artifact, and it stays behind. If it is your own sentence about what you did, it is your record, and it comes with you.

One honest caveat. This distinction is usually clear, and it is meant as a practical habit, not a legal ruling. Ownership can be genuinely unsettled in some situations, such as contract work, work made for hire, or specific terms you agreed to. Those are legal questions, not writing questions. Where what you may keep is unclear, the one rule governs: leave it out, and ask someone qualified.

LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. The line between a personal account and employer-owned material, and any situation-specific ownership questions (work made for hire, contractor versus employee, and signed agreements), are matters for counsel. This page teaches the practical habit only and states no legal conclusion. Wording confirmed with counsel before release.

Claim, example, evidence, corroboration

It helps to be precise about what a record can be, because the word "proof" means different things to different readers. There are four levels, and most honest professional accounts live at the second one.

VISUAL: A simple ascending four-level table. Not a pyramid, not a scoring system. Left to right or top to bottom, plainly.

A claim is a label you apply to yourself: "I am strategic." Anyone can write it, and on its own it carries almost nothing, because there is nothing underneath it to consider.

An example is a specific account: "Here is the situation, and the decision I made, and why." This is what a good record mostly produces, and it is far stronger than a claim. In a structured interview, which is one of the most reliable ways employers assess people, a specific example is exactly what earns weight.

Evidence is what supports the account: "Here is the documented result." Evidence is valuable where it exists, but it is often owned by your employer and frequently unavailable after you leave. This guide never asks you to take it.

Corroboration is another legitimate person or source supporting what happened: a former colleague who observed the work, or a public artifact that shows it. Corroboration can strengthen credibility, particularly in senior hiring. It is not something you manufacture, and it does not decide any employer's choice for them.

What this means for your record. Most of what you build here will be strong examples, sometimes supported by permitted evidence, sometimes prepared for corroboration. That is honest and it is enough. This guide will not imply that every entry contains documentary proof, and it will never invent a number to make invisible work look measurable. An accurate example holds up. A dressed-up claim does not.

The spine: Capture, Clarify, Carry

Every entry you make, from a two-minute note to a full record, moves through three stages. You will not think about them consciously for long. They become the shape of how you handle a piece of work worth keeping.

VISUAL: Three large stages, left to right, each with its guiding question. CAPTURE (What actually happened?), CLARIFY (What was actually yours?), CARRY (What can you responsibly take forward?). Beneath each, in smaller type, the working steps that live inside it.

Capture is speed and honesty about events. You catch the work before the details soften, even when the note is rough. What actually happened?

Clarify is the heart of the system, and the part most records skip. You separate the team's result from your own part, name the judgment inside the task, and describe what actually changed. This is where a forgettable note becomes a real record. What was actually yours?

Carry is reach and safety. You put the record in words an outsider can follow, keep only what you are permitted to hold, and tag it so you can find it when a moment arrives. What can you responsibly take forward?

Two threads run through all three stages rather than sitting in one place. The first is permission: at every stage you keep only what you are allowed to keep. The second is retrieval: you tag entries as

you go, so the record is searchable when it matters. The order of the three stages holds, though. Capture before you clarify, because a rough note beats a perfect memory you never wrote down. Clarify before you carry, because you cannot translate a contribution you have not yet separated from the team's.

YOUR FIRST 60 MINUTES

A focused first session. This is not a promise that you can reconstruct a whole career in an hour, and it is not the whole system. It is a way to start with momentum and finish the sitting with something real already in place.

The focused first session (capturing now)

Follow this in order. At the end you will have a working start, not a finished record, and that is exactly the goal.

VISUAL: A timed checklist with a visible finish line and check-off marks, so progress is obvious as the reader moves down the page. Guided doing, not a lecture.

- First few minutes. Read the one rule again, and the three tiers of permission on the Keep, Care, Never page. Choose a private home you control and turn on a password and multifactor authentication. Permission comes before storage, always.
- Next stretch. Sweep your own memory and permitted sources for the last few months. No employer files. Just what you can recall and what is already public: projects, decisions, moments that mattered. If it helps, run down the list of capture events on the next page and mark the ones that happened.
- The middle of the session. Write at least three Quick Captures from that sweep. Rough is fine. Speed beats polish.
- Then. Expand your strongest capture into a Full Entry. Fill only the fields that apply. Somewhere in it, name the judgment or the decision or the problem you prevented.
- Near the end. Translate that entry into one portable Proof Line.
- Before you finish, name one person who could confirm the work, by role, and note what they directly observed.
- Last few minutes. Set one clear reminder for your next capture, so the record keeps going. An upcoming event or a recurring date both work.

What you have at the end of the session.

- Three or more pieces of work captured.
- One contribution clarified in depth.
- One judgment, decision, or prevention example identified.

- One portable Proof Line written.
- One possible corroborator identified.
- One personally controlled record location established.
- One clear trigger for the next capture.

That is a working start. Everything after it is lighter than this.

The focused first session (already lost access)

If your access is already gone, run the session through reconstruction instead. The finish line is the same. Only the starting material is different, and nothing here treats you as behind.

VISUAL: A parallel checklist, visually a sibling of the one above, so the reconstruct reader feels they are on an equal path, not a remedial one.

- First few minutes. Read the one rule and the three tiers. Choose a private home you control and secure it. The permission rule does not relax because the timing is inconvenient; it protects you either way.
- Next stretch. Gather what is still yours to use: your own memory, previous resume versions, your public professional profile, documents you already hold, old job descriptions, certifications, and anything already public about the work. Part Seven lists these in full, with a note on where counsel confirms the boundaries. Do not reach for anything behind a closed door.
- The middle of the session. Pick one role or one year you remember well. Write three Quick Captures from memory, anchored to moments you recall clearly: a hard call, a launch, a problem you caught, a piece of feedback.
- Then. Expand the strongest into a Full Entry. Mark anything you are unsure of as unsure. An honest approximate record is worth far more than a confident wrong one.
- Near the end. Translate one entry into a portable Proof Line, and name one former colleague who could confirm the work and what they directly observed.
- Last few minutes. Set the trigger to start capturing in real time from now on, so you never have to reconstruct again.

You will finish with the same seven outcomes as the capture route. You started from cold material, and you still built something true.

PART TWO — CAPTURE

What actually happened? The goal of this stage is speed: make sure the raw material still exists before anything else is done with it. Clarifying and carrying come later.

The Two-Minute Quick Capture

The Quick Capture exists for one reason: to catch the work before it fades, in the two minutes after it happens. It is deliberately small. Five short prompts, no perfect wording required. You are not writing the final version. You are making sure the final version is still possible later.

The five prompts.

- What happened? The event or piece of work, in a line.
- What was my specific contribution or judgment? Your part, not the team's.
- What changed, improved, became possible, or was prevented? The consequence.
- Verifier role or permitted public reference. A role or a public source that could confirm it. Do not store a colleague's personal details.
- Confidential detail to keep out. Name it, so you remember to leave it out.

VISUAL: The completed example beside the blank prompts, as a filled-in card. Devin's capture, retained from Version 1.

Completed Quick Capture. Devin A., distribution center supervisor, operations, captured the same afternoon.

What happened: Recurring mispicks on the night shift were driving returns. I changed the pick-verification step and the error rate dropped. My specific contribution: I noticed the errors clustered on one workflow, proposed a second scan at pack-out, and ran the two-week trial that proved it out. What changed: Shipping errors on that line fell sharply and stayed down after the change was made permanent. Permitted verification: My operations manager, who approved the rollout. The improvement was later cited in a team update. Must stay out: The internal error dashboards, customer order data, and the returns figures themselves. I keep my own account, not the reports.

Notice what the capture does and does not hold. It holds Devin's account and a person who could confirm it. It does not hold a single employer file. That is the pattern for every capture you make.

The moments worth catching

A record does not fail because people lack discipline. It fails because nothing reminds them to open it. The fix is to tie capture to events rather than only to dates. When one of these happens, take two minutes and write a Quick Capture. Most of them take less time than the meeting that prompted them.

VISUAL: A scannable grid of the eleven triggers, each with a small mark the reader can tick. This doubles as a memory aid during the first session and a maintenance prompt afterward.

- A project or initiative ended.
- Your scope or responsibility changed.
- You received praise, feedback, or recognition.
- A problem was escalated to you, or by you.
- You caught or prevented a risk.
- Your manager or leadership changed.
- You inherited difficult or unfamiliar work.
- You made a decision under real uncertainty.
- A measurable result appeared.
- Your team changed around you.
- You started doing work above your title.

You do not need all eleven. You need the habit of noticing that one just happened. Recognizing the moment is most of the work; the two minutes of writing is the easy part.

The Full Professional Record Entry

When a piece of work matters enough to keep properly, you expand a Quick Capture into a full entry. A full entry has room for everything that makes a contribution legible later. You will not fill every field every time, and you should not try. A strong entry with six good fields beats a padded one with sixteen.

The fields are grouped so a full entry is quick to complete and easy to reread later. The groups are the shape of a good account: when and what, what was actually yours, the judgment inside it, what changed and what supports it, and how you would say it and who could confirm it.

VISUAL: The field set shown as five labeled clusters rather than one long list of twenty, with a completed example running alongside.

When and what. Date or period. Project or work event. Situation or need. Why it mattered.

What was actually yours. Formal responsibility, what you were assigned on paper. Actual ownership, what you truly drove, which is often different. Scope and constraint, the scale, complexity, or limits you worked within. People and functions involved, by role.

The judgment inside it. Decision or judgment exercised, the call you made and the options you weighed. Actions taken.

What changed, and what supports it. Outcome or observable change. Problem prevented. Quantitative evidence, only when accurate and permitted. Qualitative evidence or validation. Team result versus your honest part.

How you would say it, and who could confirm it. Internal wording, before translation. Portable-language version. Who could corroborate this, by role, and what they directly observed. Permitted evidence reference; name the source or location, do not paste the artifact or confidential content. Confidentiality and permission check. Retrieval tags: review, promotion, compensation, resume, interview, biography, transition.

VISUAL: Maya's completed full entry, retained from Version 1, shown as a filled-in card.

Completed Full Entry. Maya O., onboarding program lead, people and HR, measurable and qualitative.

Period: Second and third quarters of last year. Project: Redesign of the new-hire onboarding program for a growing operations team. Situation: New hires were taking a long time to become productive, and early attrition was high. The existing program was a slide deck and a checklist. Formal responsibility versus actual ownership: On paper I coordinated onboarding logistics. In practice I redesigned the program end to end: the sequence, the first-week plan, the manager's role, and the thirty-day check-in. Decision or judgment: I chose to move the program from information delivery to a structured first month with clear milestones, over the easier option of simply updating the deck. Outcome or change: New hires reached full productivity noticeably sooner, and early departures dropped. Managers began asking to use the model for their own teams. Evidence: Time to full productivity improved by a figure I recorded accurately at the time. Two department heads asked to adopt the approach, which I noted as it happened. Who could corroborate: The operations manager I partnered with, who saw the redesign and the results directly. Confidentiality check: I keep my own account and the fact of the improvement. I do not keep the HR system data, the employee records, or the internal reports the numbers came from. Retrieval tags: Promotion, performance review, resume, biography.

Capturing well

Four things separate a memorable entry from a forgettable one. Most records capture the first and skip the rest. This page belongs to Capture, but it is already reaching toward Clarify, which is the next and most important stage.

Assigned responsibility is where you start, not where you stop. Your job description tells a reader what you were supposed to do. It rarely tells them what you actually did. The gap between the two is where most of your real contribution lives. Record the assignment, then record what you drove beyond it.

Judgment is the part with no artifact. Anyone can list actions. Fewer people can name the decision underneath the actions: the option they chose and the ones they set aside. That choice is often the most valuable thing you did, and it leaves no trace unless you write it down. Capture the call, not only the task.

Scope makes size legible. A title hides scale. "Managed the rollout" could mean two people or two hundred, one region or twelve. Without inventing precision you do not have, note the scope you worked within: how many, how large, how complex, under what constraint.

Push past the action to the observable change. The weakest entries end with what you did. The strongest end with what became different because you did it. Push every entry one step past the action to the observable change, even when the change is modest.

PART THREE — PERMISSION AND PROTECTION

The most valuable thing this guide does is tell you what not to keep. You met the one rule on the way in, and you will meet it again at every stage. This part is where you learn the full standard, once, in depth. Permission comes before protection, and it comes before everything else.

The central rule

Permission comes before protection. A secure personal device does not make information yours to retain.

This is the sentence to remember above all others. People reach for the wrong test constantly. They ask whether the information is stored safely, whether they used their own laptop, whether it happened after hours. None of those questions is the right one. The right question is whether you are permitted to keep the information at all. Security is what you do after you have established permission. It is never a substitute for it.

What does not create permission.

- Using a personal device, a personal account, or your own phone. Ownership of the hardware does not transfer ownership of the information.
- Working outside office hours. Confidentiality obligations do not clock out at six.
- Generalizing, rounding, anonymizing, or otherwise sanitizing something. Softening the wording does not make restricted information yours.
- Believing the information is harmless, or that no one would mind. Permission is a fact about your agreements, not a guess about intentions.

The permission test. Before anything enters your record, ask one question: am I permitted to retain this outside my employer's systems? If yes, keep your own high-level account of it. If no, or if you are not sure, leave it out and, where it matters, ask someone qualified. Uncertainty is not a yellow light. For this record, it is a red one.

Keep, Care, Never

Sort everything you might record into three tiers. With practice this becomes instant.

VISUAL: The three-tier block, retained from Version 1, as the load-bearing centerpiece of this part.

Keep. Your own high-level recollection of what you did, decisions you made, problems you helped prevent, publicly disclosed outcomes, and anything your employer has expressly permitted you to retain.

Care. Numbers, client or project detail, and internal context that may be sensitive. Seek permission, use only what is already public, or leave it out. When you are unsure, treat it as the next tier.

Never. Source code, credentials, security settings, customer or employee data, unreleased product detail, internal financials, privileged or legal material, trade secrets, and any document or file owned by your employer. Never copy, forward, screenshot, download, or reconstruct these anywhere.

Generalizing information does not create permission. Use generalized wording only after you have confirmed that you are permitted to retain the underlying information. Softening the words changes how something reads, not whether it is yours to keep.

The habit is to default downward. When something sits between Keep and Care, treat it as Care. When it sits between Care and Never, treat it as Never. You may lose some detail this way, but you will keep the record accurate and defensible.

Lines that do not move

Some actions are outside the system entirely. They are not judgment calls and they are not softened by good intentions or careful storage.

- Do not forward, download, photograph, screenshot, print, upload, or copy employer-owned material into any personal system.
- Do not circumvent security controls, data-loss tools, access restrictions, monitoring, or retention rules to obtain something for your record.
- Do not retain source code, credentials, security configurations, customer or employee data, personal information, internal financials, privileged communications, unreleased product detail, trade secrets, confidential research, proprietary models, internal decks, or client materials.
- Do not paste confidential or employer-owned work information into an AI system of any kind.
- When permission is uncertain, omit the information and seek qualified advice. That is the whole procedure.

What the record actually runs on. Your own high-level recollection of what you did, information that has been publicly disclosed, and anything your employer has expressly permitted you to retain. That is the entire supply. It is narrower than people expect, and it is enough.

Lawful ways to rebuild the record

The rules above are about what you may not take. There is a second, quieter question that the strongest version of this guide should answer honestly: what may you lawfully use, especially when you are rebuilding after a change. There are legitimate channels here that are easy to overlook, and getting them right is a matter of law, not of writing style.

LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. This page is written as structure and intent only. The following channels are named because the research identifies them as lawful in many situations, but the exact wording, conditions, and cautions must be set by counsel before release. No interim legal guidance is provided here.

The channels this page will cover, pending counsel:

- Personnel-record access. In some places, current or former employees have a right to inspect or copy parts of their own personnel file, including performance records. This right varies by location and does not exist everywhere. [Exact rights, jurisdictions, timing, and limits: LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. Wording withheld.]
- Documents you already hold. Offer letters, signed reviews, pay records, certificates, and training completions are often the employee's own copies. [Which of these the employee may treat as their own, and any conditions: LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. Wording withheld.]
- Written permission. Where you want to use something that is not clearly yours, permission secured in writing is safer than a verbal yes, which is documented as failing in practice. [How to seek and record it: LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. Wording withheld.]
- Work that is already public. Published work, public announcements, and public artifacts are generally usable because they are already public. [Boundaries: LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. Wording withheld.]

Until this page is completed with counsel, the safe default is the one rule you already know: use your own recollection and information you are clearly permitted to hold, and when permission is uncertain, leave it out and ask someone qualified.

Choosing and securing a home you control

Your record needs a home. The requirements are modest, and they come in a strict order: the content must be permitted first, and only then does the storage matter. Securing a record you were not allowed to keep does not fix the problem. It hides it.

Choose a home you actually control. Use a private account that belongs to you, not an employer-owned account, drive, or device. The recommended home is your Professional Record, the copyable working document included with this guide, kept in a personal, widely readable format you own. Keep it in one place. A record scattered across four apps is a record you will not maintain.

Then secure it, in this order. Protect it with a unique password and turn on multifactor authentication. Prefer storage that is encrypted and access-controlled. Keep a backup only where the underlying content is permitted to live. Never store the record on a device or in an account your employer owns or can reclaim.

Order of operations. Permission, then storage. Every time. A locked box is only as safe as your right to hold what is inside it.

PART FOUR — CLARIFY

What was actually yours? This is the center of the system. Capture makes sure the raw material survives. Clarify is where a rough note becomes a real record: you separate your part from the team's, name the judgment no artifact shows, make invisible and preventive work legible, and give scope its true size. Most records skip this stage, which is exactly why most records are weak.

Separating a team result from your part

Most meaningful work is shared, and shared work creates a recording problem. Claim the whole result and you are exaggerating. Claim nothing and you disappear from your own record. The skill is to state the team's outcome honestly and then name your specific part within it, without inflating and without vanishing.

Two sentences, always in this order. First, the shared result: what the group achieved. Second, your contribution: the particular thing you drove inside it. "The team delivered the platform migration on schedule. My part was owning the data-integrity plan and making the call to phase the cutover, which kept us from a rushed switch." Both sentences are true. Neither one steals from the other.

VISUAL: TEAM RESULT to YOUR CONTRIBUTION, shown as a transformation, with Grace's example beside it as a filled-in card.

A manager separating the two. Grace W., engineering manager, management, team outcome and honest individual contribution.

The team result: My team of nine shipped a long-delayed platform migration, on time, with no major incidents. My actual contribution: I did not write the migration. My part was sequencing the work, protecting the team from mid-project scope changes, and deciding to run a phased cutover instead of a single switch. The judgment inside it: The phased approach was mine to argue for and

mine to own. It is the reason a risky switch did not become a bad weekend. Portable version: Led a nine-person team through a complex platform migration, delivered on schedule with no major incidents, and set the phased rollout approach that protected reliability during the transition.

Capturing work with no clean metric

A great deal of valuable work produces no tidy number. Coordination, judgment, care, and prevention rarely come with a percentage attached. This does not make the work unrecordable. It means you describe the change in credible, concrete terms instead of forcing a figure that is not real.

Describe the before and the after. When there is no metric, there is almost always a contrast. What was true before your work, and what was true after? "The handoff between the two teams kept failing; after I redesigned it, work stopped falling through the gap" is credible with no number in it, because a reader can picture both states.

Name the specific consequence. Vague improvement does not persuade. Specific improvement does. Not "made things better," but "the weekly report that used to take two people a full day now takes one person an hour." A concrete, honest particular is more persuasive than a round number you cannot defend.

Never invent the number. If you do not have an accurate figure, do not manufacture one. An invented metric is the fastest way to lose a reader's trust, because the first careful question exposes it. A well-described qualitative result is stronger than a fabricated quantitative one. Accuracy is the entire value of this record.

Problems prevented and invisible contributions

The most undervalued work in any organization is the problem that never happened. Prevention leaves no artifact by definition. The outage you caught before it spread, the error you flagged before it reached a customer, the misunderstanding you resolved before it became a conflict: none of these produce a result you can point to, because the point is that there was no result.

VISUAL: VISIBLE RESULT versus PREVENTED PROBLEM, shown side by side, so the reader sees why prevention needs a deliberate record.

Record the risk, the catch, and the likely path. To capture prevention honestly, name three things: the risk that was forming, what you noticed or did, and the outcome that was on its way if no one had acted. "A misconfiguration would likely have exposed internal access; I caught it in review and it was corrected before anything was affected" is a complete account of the judgment, with nothing invented and nothing exposed.

Stay honest about certainty. Prevention invites overstatement, so hold the line. You do not know for certain what would have happened. Say "would likely have" rather than "definitely would have." The honest version is still strong, and it is the version that survives a follow-up question.

VISUAL: Theo's prevention capture, retained from Version 1, as a filled-in card.

Prevention, captured honestly. Theo R., security analyst, technology and cybersecurity, no clean metric, problem prevented.

The risk forming: During a routine review I found that a group of accounts had been granted more access than their roles required. What I did: I traced how the access had been assigned, flagged it, and worked with the owning team to correct it and to close the gap that had allowed it. The path avoided: Left in place, the excess access would likely have become a real exposure. It was corrected before it was used. Kept versus left out: I keep my account of the judgment and the fix. I keep no logs, no account names, no security configuration, and no internal tooling detail.

Scope you carried without the title

Some of the most common senior work is the hardest to record, because it never got a name. You absorbed a departed manager's responsibilities. You ran a function the org chart still lists under someone else. You made director-level calls with a manager's title. The work was real. The title did not move, and so nothing wrote it down.

Say the work in ordinary language first, before reaching for any label. Not "expanded my span of control," but "when my manager left, I took over the team's planning, the budget conversations, and the two hardest client relationships, and no one backfilled the role for nine months." A reader understands that immediately.

Then give it its true size and name the judgment inside it. Scope is what makes uncredited work legible: how many people, how much budget, how many functions, over how long, and what you decided that a person at your titled level would not normally decide. You are not claiming a title you did not hold. You are recording, accurately, the scope you actually carried, so that it counts as what it was.

VISUAL: A before-and-after of an uncredited-scope story, from a flat "took on more" to a legible account of scope and judgment, shown as a filled-in card.

Scope without the title. A senior manager absorbing director-level work.

The situation: A director left and the role sat open. I was asked to "keep things running." Actual ownership: For nine months I owned the team's roadmap, ran the quarterly planning and budget discussions, and carried the two most difficult partner relationships, in addition to my own role. Scope and constraint: A team of eleven, a budget line I had not previously owned, and three cross-functional partners, with no change to my title or level. The judgment: I decided which of

the director's commitments to hold and which to renegotiate down, rather than trying to carry all of them and failing quietly. Portable version: Held director-level responsibility for a team of eleven for nine months during an open role, owning the roadmap, planning, budget conversations, and the most difficult partner relationships, and deciding which commitments to protect under the constraint. Kept versus left out: My own account of the scope and the calls. Not the budget figures, the partner names, or any internal document.

Who could confirm this

Institutions tend to have short memories. Formal employment verification is often limited to basic details such as your title and your dates, while the people who worked closely with you may remember far more of the contribution itself. When you leave, that firsthand memory is often the part that lasts. So while the work is fresh, note who saw it.

For an entry worth keeping, add two small things: who could confirm this, by role, and what they directly observed. "The operations manager I partnered with, who saw the redesign and its results." That is all. You are recording that a witness exists and what they witnessed, so that later, if it is ever useful, you know who to prepare with specifics.

Keep this narrow, on purpose. This is corroboration readiness, and nothing more. It is not networking, not outreach scripting, not referral strategy, and not personal-brand building. Record the role and the observation. Do not store a colleague's private contact details or personal information inside your record.

What corroboration can and cannot do. Corroboration can strengthen credibility, particularly in senior hiring, where informal conversations often carry weight. It does not decide an employer's choice, and this guide will never suggest that it does. Its job is honest: to make sure that when your account matters, someone who saw the work is ready to confirm it.

LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. Guidance on capturing another person's observations, including any privacy considerations in recording what a named individual did or said, is confirmed with counsel before release. This page stores role and observation only, and no private personal detail.

PART FIVE — CARRY

What can you responsibly take forward? Capture kept the material, Clarify made it honest, and Carry makes it usable: said in words an outsider can follow, kept only where you are permitted to keep it, and ready for the moments that ask for it. Carry does one kind of translation, the general kind. It stops before deciding what your work means for a particular destination, which is a different job and a later page.

Translate: from internal language to portable language

A record only your current employer can read is a record that expires when you leave. Translation is the skill of saying the same true thing in words an outsider can follow. It is not embellishment and it is not lying. It is the difference between a private shorthand and a description that travels.

VISUAL: INTERNAL LANGUAGE to PORTABLE LANGUAGE, shown as a transformation, with the eight moves as paired rows.

Most entries need one of eight moves. Name to function: "Ran Project Northwind" becomes "Led the customer–data migration." Assignment to contribution: "Responsible for reporting" becomes "Rebuilt the reporting so leaders could act on it." Activity to consequence: "Held weekly reviews" becomes "Caught risks early enough to prevent slippage." Team to your part: "We launched it" becomes "I owned the rollout plan for the launch." Acronym to meaning: "Cleared the KYC backlog" becomes "Cleared a backlog of customer identity checks." "Helped with" to real role: "Helped with the audit" becomes "Prepared the evidence and answered the auditors directly." No number to credible detail: "Improved the process" becomes "Cut a two–day task to a few hours." Number to scale: "Handled 40 accounts" becomes "Managed 40 enterprise accounts across three regions."

A ninth line is different, because it keeps you safe rather than clear. Sensitive to permitted: turn sensitive detail into a permitted, high–level description, and never use translation to smuggle restricted information out in disguise. If the only accurate version would expose something you may not keep, the correct move is to omit it, not to reword it.

What translation is, and is not. This is general translation: plain language an outsider can follow, with your scope and context kept attached. It is not a judgment about whether your experience fits a particular role, industry, or employer. Saying your work clearly does not, by itself, make it portable to a chosen destination, and being portable does not guarantee that a given employer will value it. Those are separate questions, and the last page of this part is where this guide hands them off.

Build: the Proof Line

A Proof Line is a single, plain–language sentence that carries the most useful parts of an entry in a form you can drop into a review, a resume, or a conversation. It is the portable end product of everything the record holds. You build it by combining, in whatever order reads well, up to five ingredients: the condition you were responding to, your part, the scope or constraint, the outcome, and the support, meaning permitted evidence or validation when you have it.

VISUAL: The Proof Line built in front of the reader from Maya's ingredients, retained from Version 1.

Maya's Proof Line: "Redesigned new-hire onboarding for a growing operations team, cutting time to full productivity and reducing early attrition, with the model later adopted by two other departments."

A Proof Line does not need a number to be strong, and it must never contain an invented one. It also never claims sole credit for a shared result. If a line would only sound impressive by overstating your ownership, it is not finished. It is wrong.

A Proof Line is general on purpose. It is a true, reusable sentence you keep, not a version shaped for a particular job, employer, or application. Tailoring your work to a specific target is a separate step, and a later one, and it is not this guide's job.

See it work: before and after

Translation is easiest to learn by watching it happen. Each pair below keeps the same underlying truth. The weaker version is internal, vague, or overclaimed. The stronger version is portable, specific, and honest.

VISUAL: The before-and-after pairs, retained from Version 1, as a two-column table.

"Owned the Q3 OKR for the CS org" becomes "Set and delivered the quarter's top goal for the customer support team." "Helped migrate to the new platform" becomes "Owned the data-integrity plan for a platform migration and phased the cutover to protect reliability." "Improved team efficiency" becomes "Redesigned a weekly reporting task from two days to a few hours." "Single-handedly saved the launch" becomes "Made the call to delay one day to fix a data issue, which kept the launch from shipping broken." "Handled a security thing" becomes "Found and corrected an access gap in review before it could be exploited." "Did a lot of cross-functional work" becomes "Coordinated three teams to resolve a recurring handoff failure between them."

Read the stronger column again and notice what none of them do. None invents a number. None claims a whole team's work. None exposes a name, a system, or a file. They are simply the true thing, said well enough to travel.

Where the record becomes useful

Once your record is honest and portable, it earns its keep at the moments that ask for an account of your work: a performance review, a promotion case, an internal move, interview preparation, a career pivot, re-entry after a break, and unexpected change. Part Eight shows which entries to pull for each of these.

This guide gets you the raw material and stops there. It does not teach you how to interview, negotiate, write a resume, or decide which of these moves to make. Those are real skills and real decisions, and they are deliberately not this guide's job.

What would not travel: the edge of translation

There is one more question that belongs here in shape but not in scope. General translation makes your work readable to any outsider. It does not tell you what your experience means for a specific destination: which parts would carry to a particular role, industry, or level, which parts would not, and what you would need to relearn to be credible there.

That question is real and it matters. It is simply a different job, and answering it well needs a chosen destination and a different tool. When you reach it, note the question and carry your record forward to it, rather than trying to answer it inside these pages.

VISUAL: A quiet seam, not a sales page. A single line that hands off, pointing to the Field Kit and the wider Capability Formation work for destination decisions.

Keep the Proof builds the honest, portable record. The Capability Formation Field Kit and the Career Move Review read what that record means for a direction you are considering, what would travel, and what you would need to earn again. This guide's work is done when your record is true, portable, and safe to keep.

PART SIX — WORKED EXAMPLES

Different functions, different levels, one discipline. You have already seen Devin in operations, Maya in people and HR, Theo in security, Grace in engineering management, and a senior manager carrying director-level scope. A few more complete the set, chosen to cover the kinds of senior work that leave the weakest automatic trail. Each follows the same card format: the work, the judgment, what changed, the portable version, and what is kept versus left out.

A sensitive context, handled by omission

Priya N., senior internal auditor, finance, audit, and risk.

The work: I led an internal audit of a financial process and identified a control weakness that had gone unnoticed for some time. The judgment: I decided which findings were material enough to escalate and how to frame them so they would be acted on rather than argued with. Why this one is delicate: The subject matter is sensitive and specific to my employer. The correct record is my own high-level account, not the findings, the figures, or the systems involved. Portable version: Led an internal audit that surfaced a significant control weakness, and framed the findings so leadership acted on them. No confidential detail retained. Kept versus left out: Kept my role, my judgment, the fact of the outcome. Left out the specific process, the numbers, the named systems, and every working paper.

Value from coordination, not output

Sam B., clinical research coordinator, healthcare and research.

The work: A study was stalling because three groups, clinical staff, data management, and an external partner, were working from different assumptions. My actual contribution: I had no formal authority over any of the three. My part was seeing why they were stuck, building a shared plan, and keeping it moving without a title that required them to listen. The outcome: The study got back on schedule. My name appears on no deliverable, because the contribution was the coordination itself. Portable version: Coordinated three functions with no formal authority to unblock a stalled research study and return it to schedule, working through influence rather than mandate.

A decision under uncertainty, with an outcome no one can cleanly claim

Andre M., operations manager, manufacturing.

The work: A supplier looked likely to miss a critical delivery, and I had to decide whether to switch to a costlier backup before I could be sure the first would fail. The judgment: I chose to split the order, paying more to protect the timeline, on incomplete information, knowing I might be spending money I did not need to. What changed: The primary supplier did slip, and the split kept the line running. I record this honestly as a judgment under uncertainty, not as a clean win, because if the supplier had delivered, the same decision would have looked like an unnecessary cost. Portable version: Made a time-critical sourcing call under uncertainty, splitting an order to protect a production timeline when a key supplier looked at risk, and accepted a known cost to avoid a larger one. Kept versus left out: My reasoning and the decision. Not the supplier, the contract, or the figures.

Developing a person, which leaves almost no trace

Lena K., team lead, marketing.

The work: A capable analyst on my team was stalling and close to leaving. Over two quarters I changed how I gave them work and feedback, and moved them onto higher-stakes projects with support. My contribution: The development was the work: the coaching, the deliberate stretch assignments, the protection while they found their footing. What changed: They stayed, took on a role a level up within the year, and now lead work I used to do. There is no artifact for any of it. Portable version: Coached a stalling analyst over two quarters through restructured feedback and deliberate stretch work; they took on a higher-level role within the year, having been close to

leaving before. Kept versus left out: My own account of what I did and what changed. Not the person's private performance details or any HR record.

Repairing a relationship between two functions

Marcus D., program manager, technology and operations.

The work: Two teams that had to work together had stopped trusting each other after a project went badly, and the dysfunction was slowing everything they shared. My contribution: I was not asked to fix the relationship; I decided it was the real blocker. I ran the difficult conversations, rebuilt a shared way of working, and stayed close until the habit held. What changed: The two teams began shipping shared work on time again. The repair itself is the contribution, and it shows up in no one's metrics. Portable version: Diagnosed a breakdown between two functions as the true cause of repeated delays, and rebuilt a working relationship between them, restoring reliable delivery of shared work. Kept versus left out: My account of the judgment and the work. Not names, not the internal history, not any private detail about the people involved.

Pre-break experience, assembled after time away

Rosa V., returning after a two-year caregiving break.

The work: Before my break I had led a significant piece of work, and after two years away I needed to assemble it into a record I could stand behind, honestly dated. My contribution: I rebuilt the account from my own memory, my prior resume, and what was already public, and I marked clearly what I was sure of and what I was not. What changed: I re-entered with a clear, dated account of senior work rather than an apology for a gap. Portable version: Led [the pre-break initiative] to [its outcome], assembled and honestly dated after a career break, distinguishing what is verified from what is recalled. Kept versus left out: My own recollection and public information. Nothing from a former employer's systems. Recency is a real screen, and this record does not pretend the work is more current than it is.

One item, all the way through

Here is a single piece of work carried through the entire system: Quick Capture, to Full Entry, to Proof Line, to retrieval tag, using Theo's prevention work from earlier.

VISUAL: The four stages of one item shown in sequence, retained from Version 1.

Quick Capture: Found over-broad access on a set of accounts during a routine review; traced how it happened, flagged it, and drove the fix and the process gap behind it; a likely exposure was prevented before the excess access could be used; the owning team's lead can confirm it; all logs,

account names, tooling, and configuration stay out. Full Entry, the fields that matter here: assigned to routine access reviews, actually drove a correction and a process change; chose to treat a quiet finding as urgent and fix the cause, not just the instance; the excess access was removed and the process gap closed; no clean metric, credible qualitative outcome confirmed by the owning team. Proof Line: "During a routine access review, I found and corrected over-broad account access and closed the process gap behind it, preventing a likely exposure before the excess access could be used." Retrieval tags: performance review, promotion, resume, interview.

PART SEVEN — RECONSTRUCT

Already lost access? Start here.

Perhaps you are reading this after a change, not before one. The record you wish you had does not exist, and the systems that held the details are closed. This is not a failure, and you did not miss your only chance. If the change has already happened, you can still rebuild a useful account. You simply start differently.

What reconstruction can and cannot recover

A reconstructed record will not be as complete as one captured in real time, and it should not pretend to be. What it can be is honest, useful, and enough to carry into the moment in front of you. The goal is not to recover everything. It is to rebuild what you can stand behind, mark clearly what you cannot, and then start capturing forward so you never have to do this again.

The rule does not relax because the timing is inconvenient. Work only from what you are permitted to use: your own memory, information that is already public, and anything you already hold or were expressly permitted to keep. What is not usable is a copy of anything you took, or access you were not meant to retain.

Where the record still lives

Even after access ends, more remains than people expect. These are the lawful places a professional account can be rebuilt from.

VISUAL: A sources checklist the reader can work down, gathering material before writing.

- Your own memory, anchored to moments you remember clearly.
- Previous versions of your resume.
- Your public professional profile and its history.
- Documents you already hold, such as offer letters, signed reviews, pay records, and certificates.

- Personal calendars, where appropriate.
- Old job descriptions for roles you held.
- Certifications and training completions.
- Public announcements, press releases, and annual reports that mention the work.
- Public work and artifacts already in the open.
- Former colleagues who directly observed the work, for what they can honestly confirm.

LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED. Several of these sources sit near employer-owned information and near questions of what a former employee may lawfully retain or request. The exact boundaries, and any personnel-record rights, are set by counsel on the "Lawful ways to rebuild the record" page. Where a source approaches something your employer owns, the one rule governs: if it is not clearly yours to use, leave it out and ask someone qualified. Wording withheld pending review.

Rebuilding honestly, and marking what you know

Work role by role, or year by year. Recall the major projects and decisions of each, anchor to the moments you remember most clearly, write Quick Captures from memory, and expand the strongest into full entries. Then start capturing in real time.

The honesty of a reconstructed record lives in how you mark each part of it. Label every entry, or every field, at one of four levels, so you never present a memory as a fact.

VISUAL: The four certainty levels shown as a small, calm key the reader applies to reconstructed entries.

- Known. You are certain, and you could stand behind it under a direct question.
- Supported. Something you hold or that is public backs it up.
- Remembered but not verified. You recall it clearly, but you have nothing outside your memory to confirm it.
- Uncertain. You think it happened roughly this way, but you are not sure of the specifics.

An account marked this way is stronger than a confident one, not weaker, because it tells a careful reader exactly how much weight each part can bear. Reconstruction has a ceiling. Name it, work within it, and let the going-forward habit do the rest.

A note on how this part is built

This part is written so it could stand on its own if it ever needed to. If future evidence from real buyers shows that reconstruction is the moment people most want to buy for, the material here is clean enough to lift into a dedicated path without redesign. For Version 2, it lives inside Keep the

Proof, because the person who lost access needs the same record everyone else is building, reached through a different door.

PART EIGHT — KEEP IT CURRENT, AND USE IT

An hour to set up, then very little. The record only earns its keep if maintaining it is nearly effortless, and if you can find the right entries fast when a moment arrives.

Keeping it current

There are two useful ways to keep the record current, and they work well together. The first is to capture when something worth keeping happens. The second is a light periodic sweep that catches what you missed and keeps the record clean. Neither is required on its own, and neither is universally better. Use whichever you will actually sustain, or both.

Event-based capture. When one of the moments from Part Two happens, a project ends, your scope changes, feedback arrives, a decision is made, a risk is prevented, you take two minutes and capture it. It suits work that announces itself.

A periodic sweep. A short monthly or quarterly pass catches the work that did not arrive as an obvious moment, and gives you a chance to clean and correct the record. It suits work that accumulates quietly. The two routines below are here for readers who want a rhythm.

- A monthly sweep, about ten to fifteen minutes. Look back over the month's projects, decisions, feedback, changes, and problems you helped prevent. Add Quick Captures for anything worth keeping, expand the most significant into a full entry, run the confidentiality check, and tag each item.
- A quarterly review, about thirty minutes. Read the quarter's entries in one sitting, remove duplicates and anything too vague, correct overstatement while you still remember, translate the strongest into Proof Lines, and note where evidence is thin without drawing any conclusion about your career from the gap.

Whether you keep to events, to routines, or to both is yours to settle by what you actually sustain. The quarterly review, if you use it, is housekeeping, not a verdict. Noticing that you have little evidence of a certain kind of work is a prompt to capture more of it, nothing more.

Retrieving the right evidence

The whole point of tagging is this moment: something is about to happen, and you need the right entries fast. This tells you which kinds of entries to pull for each occasion. It is a guide to retrieval,

not a course in how to interview, negotiate, or write a resume. It gets you the raw material. What you do with it is yours.

VISUAL: The retrieval table, retained from Version 1, occasion on the left and what to pull on the right.

Performance review: outcomes and prevented problems from the review period, with honest scope. Promotion case: judgment, ownership beyond your title, and work at the next level. Compensation discussion: scope, results, and contributions others have recognized. Internal application: work relevant to the new team, translated out of your current group's language. Resume preparation: your strongest Proof Lines across roles, each honest and portable. Interview preparation: entries with a clear situation, your decision, and the result, ready to tell aloud. Biography or introduction: a few durable, senior-sounding contributions stated plainly. Proposal or portfolio: permitted outcomes that show the kind of work you deliver. Unexpected transition: everything, quickly, because the record is now the only copy you have.

The optional, privacy-conscious AI prompt

Everything in this guide works without any AI. This tool is optional, and it is for one narrow job: helping you translate an entry you have already written into portable language. Before the prompt, the rule that governs it.

Never paste employer names, customer names, colleague names, proprietary detail, employee information, sensitive metrics, code, security information, or any confidential material into an AI system. Give it only your own non-confidential account, already stripped of anything you may not keep. The permission rules in this guide apply to AI tools exactly as they apply to everything else.

The prompt. "You are helping me describe my own work accurately for my private professional record. I will give you only non-confidential information about what I did. Work only with what I provide. If context is missing, ask me for it rather than inventing anything. Never invent numbers, percentages, or results. Preserve my actual level of ownership, keep any team result separate from my individual contribution, and preserve the scope I worked within. Translate internal language into plain, portable language an outsider could understand, and help me refine a single Proof Line. Flag anything that sounds inflated, vague, or unsupported so I can correct it. Do not write a resume, an interview answer, a profile, or anything tailored to a specific job or employer. That is outside this task."

The AI does not decide what is true. You do. Treat every version it returns as a draft to check against your own memory and this guide's rules, never as a finished record.

PART NINE — THE RECORD YOU OWN

The teaching in this guide points at one thing: a record you control and can keep for years. That record is a working document, and it should live where it is easy to search, easy to copy, and

entirely yours.

Your Professional Record

Included with this guide is your Professional Record: a copyable working document that holds everything the system produces, in a plain, widely readable format you own and control. It is the long-term home the handbook has been preparing you to keep. It gathers the capture log, your full entries, your corroboration notes, your Proof Lines, and a simple index, so any entry is a search away.

The Professional Record is deliberately platform-neutral. It does not require any particular app, spreadsheet, or service, and this guide does not recommend one, because the evidence for any single choice is not there. What matters is that it is personally controlled, searchable, easy to duplicate, and kept somewhere your employer does not own. Its full structure, every field and prompt, is laid out in the Professional Record itself.

Fillable and printable pages

If you prefer to write by hand or type into a form, printable and fillable versions of the tools are available as an option. They hold the same fields as the Professional Record. Use whichever you will actually maintain. The medium does not matter to the discipline; keeping the record current does.

CLOSING

The operating summary

Everything in this guide, on a single page you can return to.

The rule: keep your own account and what you are permitted to retain. Never copy or reconstruct what your employer owns. When unsure, leave it out.

The spine: Capture it while it is fresh. Clarify your part from the team's, and name the judgment and the prevention. Carry it into portable words, kept safely and tagged for later.

The tools: a two-minute Quick Capture for speed, a Full Entry for what matters, general translation into portable language, and a Proof Line as the portable end product.

The rhythm: a focused first session to set up, then keep it current by capturing when something happens, by a light monthly or quarterly sweep, or by both, whichever you will sustain.

The use: pull the right entries for reviews, promotions, compensation, internal moves, resumes, interviews, biographies, proposals, and sudden change.

If you remember only one line: a secure personal device does not make information yours to retain. Permission comes first. Everything else is craft.

The edge of the tool

This guide has a deliberate boundary, and naming it is part of using it well. Keep the Proof builds and translates the record of your work. It does not interpret what that record means for your position, your direction, or your next move. Those are real and important questions. They are simply not this tool's questions.

What this guide answers: what happened and what was my contribution; what decision or judgment I exercised; what changed and what evidence supports it; how I describe it truthfully in portable language; and where and how I keep a permitted record of it.

What it deliberately does not answer: whether my career is stalled or what state it is in; whether this role is still building me, or whether I should stay or leave; what move I should make, or whether a specific destination will value my work. A record can be honest and portable and still meet a market, a committee, or a bias it cannot control. This guide is careful never to suggest that better wording changes those things.

A quiet pointer, not a sales pitch. If you later want to interpret what your current work is building toward, or read what would travel to a direction you are considering, a separate tool from The Density Group, the Capability Formation Field Kit, is designed for exactly that reading. It is a different job for a different day. This guide's work is done when your record is honest, portable, and safe to keep.

About the author

Temidayo Afonja is the Founder and Principal of The Density Group. Her career spans nearly two decades and eight industries, across accounting and audit, cybersecurity, people and workforce work, diversity and inclusion work, and both consulting and operating roles. The through line is not one specialty. It is proximity, from several sides at once, to how work gets evaluated and how careers actually get built.

Two parts of that path shaped this guide directly. The years in audit and cybersecurity are why its confidentiality and information-risk standard is treated with real seriousness, and why it is careful never to overstate what any guide can settle for you. The years in people, workforce, and inclusion work are why it takes seriously the kinds of contribution that performance systems tend to miss. Keep the Proof is educational, not legal advice, and it cannot interpret your specific agreements or your employer's policies.

Keep the Proof grew out of a pattern that repeats in room after room: capable people who had done the work and could no longer prove it, reaching for details that had already gone. This guide is the discipline more of them needed.

Keep the record while the facts are still yours to keep.

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